Kupchan who was running the problem and who was leaving, so that I would be replacing him—and he said the whole deal was excel-

lent. He said there was absolutely nothing wrong with it in any way, provided I got along with Elderfield.

It was a relief. The degree was coming in just a few months and now, if I agreed to go in with Elderfield, it would not find me without a job. To be sure, it was not really a job— it was postdoctoral research, a position in which at best I could not stay many years and in which I was quite likely to stay only a single year. In a sense it would be as though once again I had opted for still more education while I postponed the real job crisis.

But I had to. And even a single year was one year in which I could continue trying.

I won't say it was satisfactory. Ever since 1939, when I had first failed to enter medical school, I had been improvising from year to year. Nine years had passed; it was 1948; I was twenty-eight years old; I was still improvising.

Fred Pohl was feeling the urge toward agenthood once again. He asked me where I stood as far as sales were concerned and I told him that for years I had been selling Campbell everything I wrote and had nothing outstanding—except "Grow Old with Me."

What was that? Fred wanted to know.

I explained and he offered to try to sell it for me. I had no great hopes. I had shown it to Campbell after Thrilling Wonder had turned it down, and Campbell said it might do as a complete-in-one-issue lead novel, but that in Astounding it would have to appear in two parts, and there was no natural break-point. He had other criticisms, too, which made me feel that even if there were a natural break-point, he wouldn't have taken it.

It turned out, though, that a young man named Martin Green-berg, 1 whom I had not yet met, was thinking of going into the science-fiction book-publishing business, and Fred thought he might be talked into doing "Grow Old with Me." There wouldn't be much money in it, but a book was rare in the science-fiction world and it would involve much prestige. It might lead to better things, and why allow a manuscript to do nothing but eat its head off in a drawer?

1 Warning! Years later, I met and worked with another Martin Greenberg, one